

Module Title: Individual Research Project / Screenwriting, FTP yr.3

Module Number: TFT00086H-A

Taught in Semesters 1 & 2, 2024-25

Project Supervisor:

*Please complete this 1-page project cover sheet for **all summative submissions***

SCREENWRITING PROJECT COVER SHEET

TITLE: XI (Ghost Marriage)

WRITER: Haoyu Zhang

FORMAT: Screenplay for Feature Film

GENRE: Horror

AUDIENCE: Every audiences who like Chinese horror and any horror movies

ANTECEDENTS (2): The House That Never Dies(2014), Memento(2000)

LOCALE: China

PERIOD: Nowadays, 1931

DRAFT: 1

PAGES: 84 pages

DATE: 27th May, 2025

LOG-LINE (29 words): Four students went to an ancient Chinese mansion to collect supernatural stories, but seemed to be drawn into a story of love and hate that happened 90 years ago.

XI (Ghost Marriage)

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Final Draft

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FADE IN:

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE - NIGHT

A vast, dimly lit hall in old Peking. At its centre stands a wide coffin, resting on an elevated wooden frame. On the lid lies a black-and-white wedding portrait-blurred, the couple's faces obscured.

From the narrow seam of the coffin lid, thick blood begins to seep. It trickles down the side, dripping onto the stone floor.

A harsh, grating creak echoes through the hall—the sound of an ancient wooden door opening somewhere unseen.

The coffin remains suspended above the ground. Below it sits a pair of red cloth shoes, embroidered with golden thread.

As the room grows colder, a second pair of identical red shoes descends slowly from above, coming to rest gently atop the coffin.

INT. AIRPLANE - DAY - 2025

SAM (V.O.)

Horror stories in China? Are there any horror stories in China? You know, I haven't watched horror movies from China, Japan, South Korea or Thailand.

On the plane to China, Sam Brown (24), a British man with golden hair and blue eyes, was having an airplane meal.

EMILY

Look, Sam. China has a history of about 6,000 years. It's impossible that parents won't make up any horror stories to stop their children from going out at night, okay?

SAM

It sounds right.

CINDY

Not only that, but there are actually many!

Cindy Chan (23), of British Chinese descent, with black hair and wearing glasses, has been searching for Baidu on the computer. She turned the computer over and showed it to Emily Peters (23) ,American, and Sam.

CINDY (cont'd)

This is a local search website in China. Just enter Chinese folk tales and you can see many different horror stories. For instance, red embroidered shoes, funerals. Look here. There is a person who specializes in storytelling called Zhang Zhen.

EMILY

Wait a moment. What are you saying? How could you use the Internet on the plane?

SAM

Continue, Cindy. This white bitch doesn't even know that WIFI can be connected on international planes.

Emily looked back at Sam in shock.

EMILY

You ass-

CINDY

He has always been like this. Don't care about Emily. He often pulls up the corner of his own eye towards me.

EMILY

Eww...

Cindy shrug her shoulders.

CINDY

That didn't work, but he was very nice, just as childish as a teenager. I went on to say that the red embroidered shoes are a very classic horror element in China. Usually, after the bride turns into a ghost, there is resentment. This resentment will make her very powerful. You know...

CAPTAIN OF PLANE

Dear passengers, the plane is about to arrive at the destination.

(MORE)

CAPTAIN OF PLANE (cont'd)
Thank you for choosing our airline during this journey. The plane will land in Beijing within fifty minutes. Please turn off your small table, set your mobile phone to airplane mode, and ensure that your laptop, evaluation computer and other electronic items remain off throughout the landing.

CINDY
Who would like to be interrupted at the happiest moment?
Emily nodded vigorously.

HAJUN
I only hope that the transportation in China can be more developed. Personally, I definitely can't stand taking a bus.

CINDY
Underground. I bet Metro in London were like that fifty years ago. The subways in China will be better.

EMILY
Hey, hey, hey! We are here for tourism. Of course, we need to experience the local culture and streets. To be honest, I don't care at all whether China is developed or not. What I care about is the safety issue. At least China is very safe, okay?

CINDY
Then let's take a Didi. Don't forget that we still have a huge villa!
Cindy winked at everyone.

EMILY
That sounds great! Guys, a country with a 6,000-year-old history, aren't you looking forward to it?

CINDY
Of course, I have never returned to China. I listened to English throughout my childhood.

SAM
If there is WIFI in the villa, yes.

HAJUN
If there is being Chillin(ice cream
in Chinese pronounce)...

EMILY
Hey

CINDY
Hey

Hajun showed his teeth and smiled.

Cindy took out her mobile phone and opened the photo album.

CINDY (cont'd)
This is the place where we collected
terrifying elements this time. The
homeowner kept a large number of
elements from the last century as a
gimmick and it belongs to a homestay.

HAJUN
So do we still have to tidy up the
room by ourselves?

CINDY
Sure, all homestays are like this,
and we also paid a deposit of 5,000
Chinese yuan, which is approximately
550 pounds. It's a pity that we are
not Chinese citizens. Otherwise, we
wouldn't have to pay the deposit.

EMILY
I like this.

Emily pointed at the huge chandelier in the picture of the
villa.

EMILY (cont'd)
It looks to have a European style.

CINDY
According to my research, in the last
century, many wealthy Chinese people
would hire European designers to
design their houses.

SAM
Aren't we going to listen to folk
tales? How could there be folk tales
among the wealthy families in China?

CINDY

Then you would be wrong if you knew the landlord.

EMILY

Landlord?

CINDY

Yes, landlords were people who owned a lot of land. They were often very rich, and being rich in that era meant being able to do whatever one wanted.

EMILY

I don't understand.

Cindy put away her mobile phone.

CINDY

It seems that I have to tell you some ancient Chinese folk customs, related to the marriage of the deceased.

EXT. FOREST - NIGHT - 1931

CINDY (V.O.)

In China, people attach great importance to bloodline, that is, the bloodline of one's father.

In 1931, many torches were burning in the forest and many people were walking in it.

CINDY (V.O.) (cont'd)

Before the 21st century, China has always maintained the tradition of preferring sons to daughters. Most people believe that only sons can carry on their family's surname. Moreover, when sons grow up, they will bring their wives into their own family to start a life. However, when daughters grow up and get married, they belong to men instead of their parents. Therefore, daughters are losing money. The son is the proof of guaranteed bloodline.

A man was walking with the support of two people. He was the landlord Guoxin Zhao (54), wearing a dark golden jacket. Behind him was a woman, the bride's mother, who kept cursing the bride Jiahui Li (17).

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

Bitch! It's your good fortune that Mr. Zhang has taken a fancy to you! It's really unlucky for me to have a daughter like you! I tell you, you alone can exchange for the wealth of our entire family and your younger brother. Then he will have money to marry a wife! How dare you run away!

THE SERVANT OF GUOXIN

Mister, here we are. We are all ready once again!

GUOXIN

Ok. Hurry up! Finish the ceremony while Jiahui Li is still not conscious!

FU

Yes, my master.

INT.JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE - MOMENTS LATER - 1931

FU

Quick! Put her in!

Two servants, led by Fu (16), placed Jiahui in a huge coffin. On the other side of the coffin lay a man with bluish skin who was already dead.

GUOXIN

What else?

Jiahui's mother rolled her eyes twice and suddenly looked up.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

Sir! Nail! Don't let her move around and ruin this marriage!

GUOXIN

Yeah.

Guoxin waved his hand and two servants holding nails ran in.

GUOXIN (cont'd)

Hurry up. Fu, hold her down!

Fu quickly called on the three people to hold down Jiahui together. The two people holding nails aimed the nails at Jiahui and the bottom of the coffin, and they hit them down with hammers.

JIAHUI

Aaargh!

FU

Everyone, do your best. If she runs away, no one will survive!

JIAHUI

Let me go, please! Mom! Mom! I'm not going to university! Sorry!

Jiahui's mother covered her nose and mouth with a handkerchief and said nothing.

JIAHUI (cont'd)

Please, I've already prayed!

The servants of Guoxin were suddenly stunned.

GUOXIN

Don't listen to her! Go on!

JIAHUI

No! Fu, please save me!

Fu's face was expressionless. The two servants, one grasping the other foot and the other grasping the other hand, struck down again with the hammer. Jiahui let out a scream. Fu suddenly picked up a knife and stabbed Jiahui in the chest. Jiahui stared at Fu with wide eyes and died.

GUOXIN

Copper coins, hurry up! The time is up!

Fu hurriedly ran out and brought back the copper coins stained with black dog blood. He stuffed them into Jiahui's mouth, nose and ear holes. The copper coins were all engraved with Guangxu Tongbao. He also closed Jiahui's eyes and placed the copper coins on them.

At this moment, the ghost matchmaker came in from outside.

GHOST MATCHMAKER

From eightfold ways they tread to gloom, To Yama's hall the judges loom. Yet fate not follows nether course, 'Fore souls go beasts of ghastly force. The sin-bound scribe doth watch mankind, On stage of tears, what truths to find. No mortal sees the shadowed ford, Where Heaven weaves all cause and chord.

The ghost matchmaker examined Jiahui's seven orifices.

GHOST MATCHMAKER (cont'd)
Begin the burial.

INT. DIDI TAXI - DAY - 2025

EMILY
Hey, I have a question.

Cindy turns her head to look at Emily.

EMILY (cont'd)
What are the copper coins used for?

CINDY
According to the folk tale, you dip copper coins into black dog's blood, then put them into a bride's seven openings—you know, eyes, mouth, nose, ears—to stop the ghosts getting out.

EMILY
But these people deserve punishment, right? So why's there even a way to dodge the consequences?

CINDY
Chinese folk tales are usually like that—completely irrational. Have you heard of the Banner of Ten Thousand Ghosts?

Emily shakes her head.

CINDY (cont'd)
It's another folk tale from China, totally different from Western devils. Western devils lure people, fulfil their wishes, then claim their souls. But this Banner thing—it just grabs hundreds of thousands of souls straightaway, willing or not.

SAM
Bloody hell. What kind of warped mind thinks up something like that?

CINDY
Exactly my point. There are so many folk tales in China that people have to keep inventing crazier stories just to get attention.

HAJUN

This Banner of Ghost thing is really confusing. We don't look for this kind. We need something people can really believe.

Cindy shrugs.

CINDY

Funny, you believe in ghosts but superpowers are too much?

HAJUN

Can you say something more normal?

EMILY

Normal? Hajun, we're literally researching the paranormal here.

HAJUN

No, I mean like, sounding really real. Not too strange.

CINDY

Sure. Ever heard of the weasel?

HAJUN

Yes, I know this animal. I saw one at zoo in America.

CINDY

Have you noticed those white hairs on its back?

HAJUN

What do you mean?

CINDY

Well, every year a weasel grows exactly one white hair. When you see one completely covered in white fur, you'd better run fast, because they have about ten thousand hairs.

SAM

Or it's just albino, innit?

EMILY

Hey! Sam, you're killing the mood here.

SAM

Nah, I'm serious. Give me something science can't explain—not some kid's bedtime story.

Cindy exchanges a helpless smile with Emily.

EXT. HIGHWAY - DAY - 2025

The Didi Taxi leaves the city, heading into the suburbs on the far side of Beijing. The area becomes heavily wooded, full of dense forests. Eventually, the bus stops outside a building. The place resembles a small town but still lies within one of Beijing's districts. Plenty of people move about, and numerous construction sites dot the landscape.

EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE - DAY - 2025

The four of them step off the bus, pulling their suitcases behind them.

SAM

Looks nice, this. Proper countryside feel, way better than that city we just left.

EMILY

Totally agree. I'll always prefer places like this to bustling crowds.

Hajun holds a can of Monster in his hand.

CINDY

Hajun, you really should ease up on the Monster. You haven't slept for thirty hours—even on the plane.

HAJUN

Actually, I am not tired at all now! Very excited!

SAM

Oh my God, mate, that's just the caffeine talking. All I wanna do now is crash out.

Cindy walks towards the house, opening the villa's door using her phone.

SAM (cont'd)
Anyway, why don't we take a quick
look around this villa while it's
still daylight?

EMILY
Absolutely! Let's find out what's so
magical about this place.

INT.JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE - MOMENTS LATER - 2025

The group enters Jing Way No.4 House. The villa is
exceptionally clean, with a huge chandelier hanging from the
ceiling. It has a second floor and a spacious living room in
front of them. The house decor resembles early 20th-century
European style, though clearly refurbished, keeping the
original look intact.

CINDY
Incredible.

EMILY
Honestly, I'm still blown away. This
place is like a dream!

CINDY
Feels like stepping into a European
castle. Remember that trip we had in
Hungary?

EMILY
Oh my God, yes!

Sam rushes over near the TV, searching desperately for Wi-Fi.

Hajun sits on the sofa, slumping against the backrest.

HAJUN
I just now realise how much my butt
hurts. Fourteen-hour flight, six-hour
transfer, two hours on the bus?
Cindy, I feel like I arrived at
world's end.

CINDY
You arrived at the other side of the
world, not the end of it.

EMILY
Alright, I'm gonna check upstairs.

CINDY
I'll come with you.

Cindy and Emily head upstairs together.

Hajun shakes his head, then turns and walks out of the house.

SAM
Thank God! I've got the Wi-Fi!

Sam turns around excitedly, then freezes, startled.

SAM (cont'd)
(shock)
What?

EXT. STREET - MOMENTS LATER - 2025

Hajun walks excitedly down the street. In the distance, he sees a stretch of forest. He approaches the edge of the trees, where a wire fence blocks the path.

He picks up a twig and starts poking around, looking for insects. He spots a cockroach and uses the twig to lift it up, pressing it gently against the wire fence to check for electricity.

The fence does not seem electrified, and Hajun breathes a sigh of relief. He follows the wire, searching for an entrance. Eventually, he reaches a small stream.

EXT. STREAM - MOMENTS LATER - 2025

By the stream, two elderly men sit while four others stand nearby, all gathered beneath the shade of trees, playing Chinese chess.

Hajun walks closer out of curiosity. The old men speak loudly, their voices echoing in the quiet woods.

OLD MAN A
(in Chinese)
Game's over, mate! Still can't beat me!

OLD MAN B
(in Chinese)
That's impossible! Let me think.

Old Man A and Old Man B continue their game of Chinese chess.

OLD MAN A
(in Chinese)
How many years now? Still no
improvement from you.

Old Man B stops replying and focuses on the board.

HAJUN
Sorry, excuse me? may I ask what this
game is?

The old men continue their conversation, seemingly unaware
of Hajun.

Hajun blinks, thinking they might not understand English.

HAJUN (cont'd)
(in Chinese)
Excuse me? sorry to interrupt?

Still no reaction. None of them even glance at him.

HAJUN (cont'd)
Maybe? maybe they have bad hearing?
They speak very loud? maybe it's
related?

Hajun decides not to disturb them further. The place feels
peaceful, and he doesn't want to ruin it. Still, he's too
excited—his curiosity about the forest is overwhelming.

He notices there's no wire fence next to the stream.

HAJUN (cont'd)
If no electricity... maybe not military
place.

He checks his phone. There is signal. He steps into the
forest.

Behind him, the old men stare fixedly at his back—but Hajun
doesn't notice.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE FIRST FLOOR - SAME TIME - 2025

CINDY
Right, I'm claiming this one.

She points to a bedroom with a window facing the street.

EMILY
(smiling)
Totally your call. You're the boss
here.

CINDY
I know nothing about my own country.
I only start studying Chinese history
in the past few years.

EMILY
That's no big deal. I've already
forgotten most of America's history
anyway.

CINDY
Why? American history's only about
two hundred years long. Even I know
that much.

EMILY
Cindy, that's not very charming of
you.

Emily glances at the bedroom across from Cindy's.

EMILY (cont'd)
Alright, I'll take this one then.

CINDY
Perfect choice. Love you, Emily.

EMILY
Love you too, darling.

Sam comes upstairs.

SAM
So? you two lasses together now or
what?

EMILY&CINDY
Ow.

They glance at each other, eyebrows raised.

CINDY
Boys never understand girls'
friendships.

Cindy and Emily wink at each other, then return to their
chosen rooms.

Sam looks around the second floor and picks the bedroom directly across the hall. The floor has three bedrooms and a study.

Sam steps into his room—it's the master bedroom, very spacious. He smiles as he walks in.

INT. CINDY'S BEDROOM - SAME TIME - 2025

Cindy looks around the room. She notices a mirror and moves it so that it no longer faces the wall.

CINDY

This room gives me a weird feeling.

She opens the window. Outside, the road stretches ahead. In the distance, there's a small bridge, and beneath it, the stream flows into the forest surrounded by wire fencing. She spots Hajun near the edge of the trees.

Cindy takes out her phone and opens Snapchat, but it doesn't work. She switches to WhatsApp—it works. She snaps a photo of the forest and sends it, adding a caption: "This forest has such a creepy vibe."

EXT. FOREST - NIGHT - 2025

Hajun walks along the stream. It leads him to a river. On the opposite bank stands a red brick house, seemingly abandoned.

He takes out his phone, snaps a photo, and sends it on WhatsApp. Then, he opens the message from Cindy. It's a photo of the forest—his back is visible as he enters.

HAJUN

Love you, Hajun. Still look handsome.

He doesn't notice that the old men from earlier are missing in the photo. His focus remains on his own silhouette.

Hajun puts his phone back in his pocket and scans the area, looking for a way to cross the river. To the north, he spots a suspension bridge. It looks ancient.

EXT. FOREST - NIGHT - 1931

Jiahui runs along the forest path, lifting her wedding gown to avoid stepping on it. Her calves are covered in scratches from the undergrowth.

In the distance, torchlight flickers, drawing closer. She glances back, then scans for a way across the river. She spots a rope bridge nearby and sprints toward it.

She rushes over the bridge, turns, and tries to cut the ropes with a stone, but fails. Frustrated, she hurls the rock into the river.

FU

There's a sound over there! This way!

Jiahui looks across the river in fear and flees deeper into the forest. A small wooden hut stands nearby. She throws a hopeless glance at it but runs past without stopping.

FU (cont'd)

I see her!

He points at her silhouette vanishing into the trees.

FU (cont'd)

After her!

The group storms across the rope bridge. Fu reaches the far side first. As the others follow, the bridge collapses under their weight, plunging several into the river.

FU (cont'd)

Shit!

He dashes to the riverbank and sees the snapped rope dangling.

FU (cont'd)

That bitch! The rest of you, keep going!

He frowns at the rushing water. The servants who fall are swept away. The others are stranded on the opposite bank.

FU (cont'd)

Go get rope. Prepare to catch us!

He orders the stranded servants to return. He turns and continues the pursuit.

EXT. DEEPER IN THE FOREST - MOMENTS LATER - 1931

Jiahui limps now. Her legs are injured and a bruise rings her ankle. Fu and the servants quickly gain on her.

She dives into a cave she discovered earlier. Inside, dry brush and branches she'd hidden wait. She uses them to erase her footprints, then hides within the shadows.

Fu arrives shortly, listening intently, but hears nothing. He frowns, confused.

SERVANT A
We've lost her.

FU
Useless bastard!

Fu grabs the whip tucked in his waistband and lashes Servant A.

FU (cont'd)
Why ask me? Look for tracks! People don't just vanish!

SERVANT A
Yes, sir!

Eleven servants search the ground. Fu scans the area, fingers tightening on the whip.

SERVANT A (cont'd)
Her tracks end here!

FU
End?

He walks to the clearing with Servant A and sees no further prints. He eyes the group and notices one servant looking sideways.

Fu approaches him slowly and yanks off his hat.

FU (cont'd)
Huawei Zheng! Grab him!

The servants hesitate, then tackle Huawei Zheng (19). He struggles, but they overpower him.

FU (cont'd)
Tell me! Where's Jiahui?

Huawei screams in pain but stays silent.

FU (cont'd)
What, gone mute? Beat him!

The servants toss down their torches, draw batons from their belts, and begin to beat Huawei. He grits his teeth, refusing to cry out.

FU (cont'd)
Scream! Let's see if your Jiahui can stand watching her lover beaten to death.

HUAWEI
You wish.

FU
Harder.

They strike again, one baton landing sharply across his thigh. Huawei cries out at last.

INT. CAVE - SAME TIME - 1931

HUAWEI (O.C.)
Aaargh!

Jiahui hears Huawei's scream. She hugs her knees, trembling violently.

FU (O.C.)
If we don't find her, we're all dead.
Keep hitting him until he talks. Or until he dies.

Jiahui bites her lip. Blood trickles down her chin. She clutches her red wedding dress tightly, fingers digging through silk into her own flesh.

EXT. FOREST CLEARING - SAME TIME - 1931

Huawei is beaten by ten men. Blood runs from his mouth, his legs, his back.

FU
You stubborn little shit.

Fu turns to where Huawei had glanced—towards thick, dark woods. It would be nearly impossible to find someone inside.

FU (cont'd)
Fine. I'll kill you first. Then I'll find her. Kill him! If we can't find Jiahui, he dies with us!

The servants, eyes wild, strike harder.

SERVANT A

Talk, damn you! You want to die—we don't!

He swings harder.

The distant trees glow as more torches approach. Others have crossed the river.

FU

The master's coming. Stop.

The men freeze mid-blow, still glaring at Huawei, but obeying orders.

The light grows stronger. Guoxin steps out from the trees.

GUOXIN

Where is she?

He looks around frantically, then spots Huawei on the ground.

GUOXIN (cont'd)

Who is this?

Fu rushes to Guoxin's side, bowing slightly.

FU

Master, this is Jiahui's lover.
Huawei Zheng.

Guoxin's eyes widen. He coughs violently and points at Huawei, his hand shaking.

FU (cont'd)

He might know where she's hiding. Her trail ends here.

Guoxin coughs again, unable to speak, and shoots Fu a cold glare.

FU (cont'd)

Understood.

He waves his hand. The servants hoist Huawei up and tie him to a tree.

Fu approaches him, striking Huawei's upper abdomen with the whip.

HUAWEI

Aaagh!

He shudders in pain, stomach spasming. He gasps, forced back to alertness.

Guoxin steps forward, gazing down at him coldly.

GUOXIN

Child, protecting someone you love? I respect that. But haven't you heard the old saying? "Better to tear down a temple than ruin a marriage." Don't you understand that?

Huawei, mouth full of blood, grins.

HUAWEI

That marriage? It's a joke. Ruining it earns me merit in the afterlife!

GUOXIN

Nonsense!

He coughs violently again.

HUAWEI

Better she marries me than a corpse. Maybe your son was gay.

Guoxin chokes, furious. Fu lashes Huawei's stomach again.

FU

You're asking for death!

Huawei gasps, the pain unbearable.

HUAWEI

If I ever learn who arranged this marriage, I'll find him, even as a ghost!

A woman bursts from the crowd in tears—it's Jiahui's mother.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

Where's my daughter? No more wedding! No more money! Give me back my child!

GUOXIN

What? You mad old hag!

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

I'm not mad! I just want my daughter. She wanted university. I didn't know you'd marry her to a corpse! I was wrong! Jiahui! Where are you?

Huawei sees a glimpse of hope, but remains afraid.

HUAWEI
Auntie? you finally understand.

She sees Huawei.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
Huawei! What have they done to you?

She rushes to him, embracing him from below.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (cont'd)
Good boy? you've suffered so much.

GUOXIN
What kind of mother are you? The marriage contract is sealed. You can't back out now!

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
I don't care! I just want my daughter alive.

A sound echoes from the woods. Fu hears it, alert.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (cont'd)
Jiahui, run! It's your mother's fault! Even if I die today, you must live!

She turns and glares at Guoxin.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (cont'd)
You old bastard. You want my daughter to die with your dead son? Then you'll die with her!

She charges Guoxin with a knife. Fu sees her and lashes her down with his whip. He raises the whip again—

JIAHUI
Don't kill my mother!

She bursts out of the trees.

GUOXIN
It's her! Grab her!

The servants move fast, tackling her and binding her hands and feet.

JIAHUI

Let Huawei and my mother leave. I'll go with you.

Guoxin coughs heavily.

FU

Of course. We won't harm them.

Jiahui glares at Fu in disgust.

JIAHUI

You sick bastard. No one would mourn you if you dropped dead.

Fu freezes, then bursts out laughing.

FU

And you think someone loves you?

He steps aside. Jiahui sees her mother standing up. She isn't injured. Jiahui stares in shock.

JIAHUI

Mum?

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

Whore! You nearly got us killed! If you hadn't run, your brother wouldn't have been taken! He's my only son!

JIAHUI

I'm your only daughter.

Her mother spits in her face.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER

You're no daughter of mine anymore!

JIAHUI

What?

No one answers her. As she's lifted, Fu approaches Huawei with a knife.

JIAHUI (cont'd)

No! Fu! I'm begging you!

Fu glances at her, then smiles and plunges the knife into Huawei's chest. He cuts the rope binding Huawei's body, but leaves the noose around his neck.

FU

Let's play a game. Will he bleed out first, or suffocate? I say blood loss.

JIAHUI

You monster! Psychopath!

Fu remains silent, watching Huawei twitch and gasp, tongue slowly protruding.

FU

Looks like I missed the heart. He's hanged. I lose.

He grins, clearly pleased.

GUOXIN

Time's nearly up. We return immediately!

INT.FOREST HUT - DUSK - 2025

Hajun opens the door. The hut clearly hasn't been cleaned for years. He quickly pulls a handkerchief over his mouth and nose, waving a hand to scatter the dust. Though he finds the air disgusting, curiosity wins—his excitement about the unknown keeps him moving forward.

HAJUN

(in Korean)

Yah, fuck.

It's too dark to see clearly. After a couple of seconds, his eyes adjust. In front of him sits a table with a wooden stand—almost like a shrine. At its centre is a sculpture of a weasel. Behind it, there are name tablets, each fixed to wooden bases.

HAJUN (cont'd)

Holy shit? What have I just found?

He steps inside. The wind slams the door shut behind him, but he pays no attention—light still seeps through the windows. Hajun walks slowly towards the sculpture. The weasel is intricately carved, perfectly placed, and made of polished wood. The name tablets are all wooden too, but simpler—each one bearing only a name.

HAJUN (cont'd)

Why are you all lined up behind the weasel?

He studies the Chinese characters, trying to make sense of who these people were—and why they seem to rank beneath an animal. Most surnames read Zhao. One seems different, but it has been slashed with a blade, making the name unreadable.

Finally, Hajun looks at the weasel statue. Behind it, engraved into the wood, is a single word: "Immortal."

HAJUN (cont'd)
So? Chinese people used to see
weasels as gods? Just like Cindy
said. Maybe the ones with white fur
were divine to them.

He nods slowly.

HAJUN (cont'd)
That would explain it. But these
foolish Chinese people didn't
realise—it's just a disease.

He steps back and takes a photo, sending it via WhatsApp. No reply.

HAJUN (cont'd)
Everyone asleep?

Bored, he glances round the room. Nothing else catches his attention. He turns to leave—then notices Chinese characters carved into the door: "Do you think I look like human?"

HAJUN (cont'd)
Fuck! What is this? Was this here
earlier? Who carves rubbish like
that?

He pats his chest, trying to calm himself, and walks cautiously to the door. The characters are fresh.

HAJUN (cont'd)
What? New?

Another carving sound begins. Below the first line, fresh characters appear again: "Do you think I look like human?"

HAJUN (cont'd)
Fuck!

He jumps back in shock and kicks the door open. A white weasel stands behind it, its fur clean except for a yellow patch on the chest.

Without thinking, Hajun kicks the weasel straight into the river. Then he bolts.

EXT. FOREST - NIGHT - 2025

Hajun runs fast, his fear rising. He dashes over the rope bridge, back towards the stream. The iron fence comes into view—so do the old men, now standing beside it. They all stare directly at him.

He stops, stunned. These are the same old men from earlier—those who were playing chess.

HAJUN
What the hell? Am I hallucinating?

Still running, he jumps over the fence and sprints towards the villa.

OLD MAN A
He didn't speak to us.

OLD MAN B
He doesn't think we look human.

ALL OLD MEN
(together)
He doesn't think we look human. He
doesn't think we look human!

Hajun runs far before turning back. The old men haven't moved—they simply stare. Uneasy, he breaks into a full sprint back to Jing Way No.4 House.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE - NIGHT - 2025

Cindy wakes, reaches for her phone. 3:00 a.m. She groans, then lies back.

CINDY
Bloody jet lag.

She hesitates, then gets out of bed, still in pyjamas, and walks downstairs. The front door is ajar.

CINDY (cont'd)
Hajun must've been the last one back.
Bloody idiot didn't even close the
door.

She shuts it. The wind stops. Silence. Only the sound of water dripping onto the floor remains.

She turns to the kitchen. A faint light glows—not moonlight, but artificial.

She rubs her head and steps into the kitchen. The fridge door is wide open.

CINDY (cont'd)
I swear, Hajun, I'm going to kill you. What is this? Bad habits? Do you not zip your trousers either?

She closes the fridge, and finds Hajun standing behind the door.

CINDY (cont'd)
Fuck!

She jumps, falls to the floor, spilling water from her hand. She screams, eyes shut, for a full three seconds—then opens them.

CINDY (cont'd)
Hajun? Fuck! What are you doing?

HAJUN
God? I saw a god.

CINDY
What god? Hajun, you haven't slept all night, have you?

HAJUN
No. No. I understand now! It's the weasels. They're all weasels!

CINDY
What weasels?

She pauses, trying to make sense of his words.

CINDY (cont'd)
That's just a folk tale, Hajun. No animal lives that long.

HAJUN
No, it's true. No. It's all true.

CINDY
You're exhausted. What you need is rest. Whatever happened—we'll deal with it in the morning, alright?

She turns and walks out of the kitchen. Hajun's eyes stay locked on her.

INT.JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE SECOND FLOOR - THE NEXT DAY - 2025

SAM
What a good day!

Sam steps out of his room looking bright-eyed, clearly in better spirits and quite energised.

SAM (cont'd)
No one up yet? I'm the first? That's a record.

He walks across the landing and knocks on Emily's door.

SAM (cont'd)
Hey mate, you awake?

He then knocks on Cindy's door.

SAM (cont'd)
The sun's nearly overhead, come on!

Emily opens her door and steps out slowly.

EMILY
This is far too early. What do you expect me to do—photosynthesise?

SAM
You can try. If you've got the leaves for it.

He grins, then knocks on Cindy's door again.

SAM (cont'd)
You know what time Cindy went to bed?

EMILY
No clue. Let's check the fridge first.

SAM
Solid plan.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE GROUND FLOOR - MOMENTS LATER - 2025

Sam and Emily stand before the open fridge. It's completely empty.

SAM
Brilliant. Problem number one—we need sandwiches.

EMILY

I saw loads of convenience stores yesterday. There's even a Subway nearby. We'll be fine.

SAM

Sounds fine? but are they even open?

EMILY

Bro, this is China.

SAM

Ah. Fair point.

They turn. Hajun stands silently in the kitchen doorway.

SAM (cont'd)

Oh! Hajun, mate. Sleep well?

HAJUN

Was okay. I was so tired? I don't even remember how I got back.

EMILY

Sounds like you really passed out.

HAJUN

Hope so. Feels like I drink all night.

SAM

Not ideal. We're heading out for sandwiches. Fancy joining?

HAJUN

No thanks. If okay, can you bring me crisps?

EMILY

Try our best.

Emily and Sam leave the house. Hajun heads back to his room on the ground floor.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE GROUND FLOOR - MOMENTS LATER - 2025

Cindy comes downstairs and heads into the kitchen. She opens the fridge, finds it empty.

CINDY

What? The water and sandwiches from last night?

She freezes, closes her eyes, then gently shuts the fridge door. She opens her eyes again. Nothing.

CINDY (cont'd)
Was that all a dream?

She turns and looks toward Hajun's room.

INT.CINDY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT - 2025 - FLASHBACK

Cindy sits on her bed, shaking, eyes locked on the door.

CINDY
Hajun's not normal?

She picks up her phone and searches "spirit possession" in Chinese. The results are mostly folk tales. The comments say they're all fictional, nothing credible or newsworthy.

CINDY (cont'd)
Since 1949, China bans real ghosts from appearing—even in films and TV. They can be shown online now, but not in cinemas or on cable TV. These days, ghosts are allowed—but only in foreign productions.

She reads aloud from a news article.

A tapping comes from the window.

CINDY (cont'd)
Who's there?

She looks over—nothing outside. She sighs.

CINDY (cont'd)
Folk tales have existed since last century, especially in the northeast. Poor signal, slow communication? people relied on radio and newspapers. But in the cold, most didn't even bother turning radios on, let alone buying papers. They just talked. That's how rumours spread.

She lowers the phone.

CINDY (cont'd)
That's why so many believe in folk tales. When people face what they can't explain, they guess.
(MORE)

CINDY (cont'd)
And human imagination—once it
starts—is impossible to control.

Clouds begin to cover the moonlight. She turns on her
bedside lamp and continues reading.

She hears footsteps.

The sound comes from outside the door.

CINDY (cont'd)
Who's still up? Hajun?

She places her phone aside. The bedside lamp flickers? then
goes out.

CINDY (cont'd)
Hajun? Is that you?

The footsteps stop right at her door.

CINDY (cont'd)
Hajun? Emily?

No answer. Then—a knock. Light, but unmistakable.

CINDY (cont'd)
Emily? Is it you?

The knocking speeds up. The moonlight returns—and she sees a
pair of red cloth shoes under the door.

She dives under the blanket, trembling.

She hears the door creak open—no footsteps follow.

Slowly, she peeks out. A red bridal gown. Red embroidered
shoes. She hides again.

Silence. After a long wait, she peeks again. Nothing. The
door is closed. She pulls back the duvet completely and
scans the room. Nothing.

She creeps to the door, kneels, and peers through the gap.

A green eye stares back at her—round, unblinking, lidless.

CUT TO:

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE GROUND FLOOR - DAY - 2025

SAM
We're back! Cindy! Hajun! Sandwiches!

Cindy jumps, startled as she scrolls through something on the sofa.

EMILY

Cindy, good to see you're up.

SAM

Fridge was empty, so we grabbed food.
What'll you have?

Cindy glances at the bags in their hands, thinking.

CINDY

I'll have chicken, please.

SAM

Of course, my king.

Sam pulls out a chicken sandwich and a cold bottle of diet coke. Cindy unwraps the sandwich, takes a bite—then freezes. She places it on the coffee table and immediately begins searching for “weasel” on her phone.

INT. ANCESTRAL HALL CELLAR — NIGHT - 1931

Jiahui is tied up in Guoxin Zhao's private prison beneath the ancestral hall. She opens her eyes, staring at the iron bars. She groans, but a cloth stuffed into her mouth by the Zhao family's servants muffles the sound.

Her hands are bound tightly behind her back, and both ankles are also tied. She can barely move, only managing a faint sound.

SERVANT C

Young master's dead?

SERVANT D

I just saw it. He's really gone this time. That wedding's completely turned into a ghost marriage now.

SERVANT C

A ghost marriage?

SERVANT D

You don't know? Three days ago the master found a ghost matchmaker. The whole thing's been planned for days.

Servant C munches on peanuts. Servant D stares at him in disbelief.

SERVANT C

I knew he'd found a matchmaker. I didn't know she was a ghost matchmaker.

SERVANT D

Course you didn't. You new lot from the city—no sense of anything.

SERVANT C

Alright, then you tell me.

Servant D eats a peanut, leans in.

SERVANT D

You know there's a kind of marriage for the dead? Dead to dead. It's called a ghost marriage.

Servant C shakes his head.

SERVANT D (cont'd)

Say my son dies today, your daughter dies tomorrow. Neither of them married. When they go to the underworld, they'll be lonely. What then?

SERVANT C

You marry them after death?

SERVANT D

Exactly! Your daughter was meant to marry anyway—you probably don't care, you've got a son, haven't you? My boy doesn't. He never had a wife. He'll be all alone down there. So I buy your daughter's corpse and marry her to him. You make money. My dead son gets a wife.

SERVANT C

That sounds like a win-win!

SERVANT D

Too right. But it's not just anyone who can be a couple. You need a ghost matchmaker to tie the knot.

Servant C nods, starting to understand.

Servant D slaps him on the back, hard.

SERVANT D (cont'd)

Got it now?

SERVANT C

I think so... but this one's still alive, isn't she?

SERVANT D

Now you've lost it again. Dead and dead can marry—but so can dead and alive. You just need the living one to die.

SERVANT C

You mean... kill her?

Servant D shakes his head. Servant C goes quiet, stunned.

Fu comes down the steps.

FU

Everything's ready. Bring the bride up.

Servants C and D bow quickly.

SERVANTS C & D

Yes, sir.

EXT. FOREST OUTSIDE THE ANCESTRAL HALL — NIGHT - 1931

Two servants untie Jiahui, each lifting an arm and placing her inside a red bridal sedan chair. They bind her again. Outside, two more servants stand ready. Four men hoist the sedan and follow Fu into the woods.

A white weasel slips quietly after them.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — SAME TIME - 1931

The entire house is draped in white silk. The floor is scattered with ghost money. At the centre stands a wide coffin, placed on a wooden platform above a five-metre-deep pit.

Mourners in white robes kneel along both sides of the room. At the head, Guoxin stands silently, tears rolling down his face as he looks at the body inside the coffin. It is Weiguo Zhao (18), blue-skinned, clearly dead. Handsome, but unsettling.

Nearest to the coffin, a woman cries loudly—Ting Liu (37), Weiguo's mother.

Guoxin stares at his son in silence. A servant runs in quietly, trying not to make noise.

SERVANT E
Master, the bride has arrived.

Guoxin wipes his tears sharply with his sleeve and turns shakily toward the door.

GUOXIN
Begin the music.

INT/EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — SAME TIME — 1931

Festive wedding music bursts out—suona, drums, and gongs, just like a real wedding. The musicians wear bright red. The red sedan approaches the white-draped house. The cheerful music contrasts with the weeping inside.

GUOXIN
Granny Yin.

A hunched old woman in a tattered black robe steps forward—Siu Yin (94), the ghost matchmaker. Her face is a map of deep wrinkles, eyes almost hidden, only a glint of black visible beneath the folds.

SIU
The time has come. Let us begin.

Guoxin nods.

SIU (cont'd)
Auspicious hour! Bring down the bride!

The four men set the sedan chair onto the ground.

SIU (cont'd)
Luck is with us. Commence the ceremony!

Her voice is shockingly loud.

Two servants pull back the red curtain, carry Jiahui to the coffin and place her beside it.

Guoxin moves to sit behind the coffin. Ting sits beside him, still weeping. Siu stands between them and the coffin.

SIU (cont'd)
Groom, rise.

Two servants lift Weiguo's corpse, securing his upper body and head with a wooden frame, and fixing the lower half with another brace. They place him facing the bride.

The mourners rise, watching a dead man and a bound woman face each other as the jubilant music continues outside.

SIU (cont'd)
Bride, take your place.

Two servants untie Jiahui and hold blades at either side of her neck.

SIU (cont'd)
First bow—to heaven and earth.

The servants help Weiguo bow toward the doorway. Jiahui, trembling, follows.

SIU (cont'd)
Second bow—to parents.

The corpse is turned to face Guoxin and Ting. Jiahui bows as well.

SIU (cont'd)
Third bow—husband and wife, face each other.

The corpse is turned to face Jiahui. She stares in terror.

Just as they are about to bow, an explosion sounds outside. Guoxin leaps to his feet, stunned.

GUOXIN
What's happening?

Fu rushes to the doorway.

FU
Go and check! Now!

He points at a servant, who runs towards the firelight.

Guoxin slams his chair with his palm and sits back down.

A moment later, Huawei appears, disguised in servant's clothes.

HUAWEI

The grain stores have exploded—the
crops are on fire!

Fu glances at Guoxin. Guoxin covers his eyes and waves his
hand impatiently.

FU

Put it out—now!

SERVANTS

Yes, sir!

They rush out to fight the fire.

GUOXIN

What's that smell?

He sniffs. Smoke quickly fills the hall.

GUOXIN (cont'd)

A Fu! Fire! Put it out! A Fu!

Fu has just stepped outside. Feeling something wrong, he
runs back in and sees the smoke.

FU

Fuck! Find where it's burning—now!

The remaining five loyal servants quickly help Guoxin out.
Everyone evacuates.

Fu runs behind the house—he spots a white weasel darting
from the shadows. He stomps on it, crushing its head until
it stops moving.

FU (cont'd)

You little bastard. You ruined
everything five years ago, and you
dare show up again?

He checks around—no fire, no witnesses—then returns to the
front. The smoke has already cleared.

FU (cont'd)

Master—it was just a weasel.

GUOXIN

(shocked)

A weasel?

He falls into thought.

GUOXIN

Perhaps it was the divine weasel... the one I was told about. Is it dead?

FU

Smashed under my boot.

Guoxin smiles, claps Fu on the shoulder.

GUOXIN

Good. Very good.

SERVANT D

Sir! The bride's gone!

FU

What?

GUOXIN

What?

FU

Shit!

More servants return from the fields.

FU (cont'd)

We were tricked—fuck! Front door had guards, I checked the back—no one there. The right! The forest! Grab torches—move!

SERVANTS

Yes, sir!

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — DAY - 2025

CINDY

The weasel asking to be deified?

Emily sits on the sofa backrest, taking a bite of her sandwich.

EMILY

What does that mean?

CINDY

Generally, weasels symbolise good things—they protect households. This goes back to last century, maybe earlier. So yes, they're seen as a kind of positive spirit.

SAM

Why are you looking this up?

Cindy thinks of Hajun last night. Something still feels off.

CINDY

It's a folk tale, but look here. There's a situation where the weasel can actually kill people. After training for perhaps a thousand, maybe several thousand years—when their white fur starts growing beyond the back—they can transform into humans. And after ten thousand years, they become gods. But there's a shortcut: the weasel asks to be deified. It'll ask a person—"Do I look like a human?" If the answer is yes, the weasel gains belief and can ascend sooner. If not, everything it worked for is destroyed.

EMILY

I don't get it. Can't it just keep training and ask again in a few more years?

SAM

Its little heart's fragile.

CINDY

Maybe.

EMILY

Still sounds like it's got nothing to do with people.

CINDY

It does. If you say it doesn't look like a person, it'll kill you and live on in your place—take your form. Revenge, basically.

SAM

Right... But if you say yes, aren't you helping it?

Cindy shakes her head.

CINDY

You make it a god. Then it needs you to keep believing in it. If your belief wavers, it loses its powers.

(MORE)

CINDY (cont'd)
So you become the offering—your life,
your soul, in exchange for its
divinity. But in return, it might
bless your family with wealth or
power.

EMILY
So either way, you die.

CINDY
Exactly. Instant death or slow death.
Take your pick.

SAM
Well, I'll try being nice. Something
like, "You look like a sweet furry
girl."

Emily gives Sam a cold look.

SAM (cont'd)
What? At least I'd die worshipping
something I like.

CINDY
First off, I don't know if the weasel
understands English. Do you
understand Chinese?

SAM
So what? If it's lived for thousands
of years, it must speak every
language. English has history too.
Maybe it just doesn't do Korean.

CINDY
Koreans understand Chinese
characters. Where is Hajun?

SAM
Oh right—Hajun! We brought crisps for
you, mate!

Sam walks to Hajun's room with the crisps.

SAM (cont'd)
Hajun, mate? You alright?

Cindy watches Hajun's door tensely.

SAM (cont'd)
He's probably sleeping.

The door opens. Hajun sniffs the air.

HAJUN

Chicken?

SAM

Oh, yeah. We got four chicken sandwiches.

Hajun stares blankly at the bag by Sam's foot, then looks up and forces a stiff smile.

HAJUN

Thank you... very much.

SAM

Cheers, mate.

Hajun bends, picks up the bag, and quietly shuts the door.

CINDY

Don't you think he's acting weird?

EMILY

I don't know. I don't really pay attention to him.

SAM

Maybe he's just tired. He came back last, remember? And we still don't know when exactly.

Emily nods in agreement.

CINDY

Maybe. But since last night something's just... felt wrong. I don't know why.

EMILY

Could be the lack of photosynthesis.

SAM

You twit—it's vitamin D deficiency.

EMILY

It's just a joke. But hey, maybe you only know about vitamin D because you live in sunless Britain.

SAM

You cheeky cow.

CINDY
Alright, enough. Let's head out, get
a bit of local culture in. Don't
forget why we're here.

SAM
Oi, that's my line.

CINDY
Let's go.

EXT. STREET — SHUNYI DISTRICT, BEIJING — DAY — 2025

SAM
So we're splitting up, yeah?

CINDY
Yes. I'll ask about folk tales. You
two take some scenic shots.

EMILY
Why don't we get to ask about folk
tales this time?

CINDY
Because the English speakers are
mostly in the city. Out here? Not so
likely.

SAM
Yeah, Chinese people don't really
bother with English—same as
Americans. Their country's big
enough. They don't need it unless
it's for exams.

CINDY
Don't worry. I've installed
translation apps on all your phones.
You won't get lost asking for
directions.

SAM
Thank you, my king. You're the best.

Cindy smiles slightly and heads off toward the stream,
parting ways with Sam and Emily.

EXT. EDGE OF THE FOREST — MOMENT LATER — 2025

Cindy walks slowly with her notebook, approaching the stream
where Hajun entered the woods yesterday.

The forest feels overwhelming. She stops, hesitant.

CINDY
Hajun... what did you really see?

HUAWEI (O.V.)
If I were you, I wouldn't be so
curious about this forest.

CINDY
Sorry?

Huawei steps closer, holding a cold bottle of cola. He
smiles and extends his hand.

HUAWEI
I saw your group yesterday. You're
staying at Jing Way No.4, right?

Cindy eyes him cautiously, but shakes his hand. His grip is
cold and barely touches her fingertips.

CINDY
Do you live here?

HUAWEI
I've always lived here. It's a lovely
place.

CINDY
I agree. But why shouldn't I go in?

Huawei glances over at the stone table and stools under the
trees.

HUAWEI
The sun's too harsh. Come, let's sit
there. I'll tell you a folk tale.

Huawei looks striking—denim jacket, t-shirt, dark cool-
fabric trousers. Cindy studies him a moment, then follows
him into the shade.

CINDY
Is there something unusual about this
forest?

INT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — MAGIC TIME - 1931

JIAHUI
Huawei, I'm ready.

HUAWEI

But I'm not.

JIAHUI

Why? We made our vow at the wedding stone. We are married. And the day after our wedding, you want me to marry a dying man?

HUAWEI

No! I never said that! I'll get you away from that corpse, I swear!

JIAHUI

Then kill Guoxin Zhao!

HUAWEI

I've never killed anyone...

Huawei's eyes fill with tears.

JIAHUI

Coward. I'll do it myself.

HUAWEI (V.O.)

One side is morality and law. The other—my dearest love. I freeze. I just watch her walk away from the room we shared for one day and one night. I don't know what's wrong with me. I don't dare to think what killing Guoxin Zhao would mean. I'd be a murderer for life. My teacher would never allow it.

Huawei walks to the doorway, staring at Jiahui's back.

HUAWEI (V.O.) (cont'd)

What did she just say? I didn't catch it... but her expression was wrong.

He looks up at the setting sun—the magic hour. He closes his eyes for five seconds.

When he opens them, Jiahui is gone. He turns to look at the haystack.

HUAWEI (V.O.) (cont'd)

Whether it's your parents, your wife, your son or daughter—it doesn't matter how they see you. The world's opinion doesn't matter.

His teacher's words echo in his memory—Fangxiu Chen.

FANGXIU (V.O.)
What matters is that you respect
yourself.

HUAWEI (V.O.)
What matters is that I respect
myself.

EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MAGIC TIME — 1931

Jiahui runs to the house and sees it draped in white. Paper
coins scatter the floor. Everyone inside is weeping.

JIAHUI (V.O.)
Weiguo is dead?

JIAHUI
So it's already happened? Then I
don't need to marry him?

She moves to a better vantage point. The doors are wide
open. Amongst the white decorations hangs a large red
double-happiness symbol.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
They want to...

Suddenly, she collapses. Fu stands behind her.

FU
How did you find out? Spying isn't
something a good student does.

EXT. FOREST — SAME TIME — 1931

Huawei crosses the stream and reaches the riverbank. In the
distance, he sees the wooden hut. He crosses the rope
bridge, thinking. He draws a knife and half-cuts one side of
the bridge.

HUAWEI (V.O.)
This should still hold the weight of
one adult.

He glances back at the bridge, then heads for the hut.

INT. FOREST HUT — MOMENT LATER — 1931

Huawei enters. He takes a flintlock from his pocket and
lights a nearby candle. A wooden sculpture becomes visible.

HUAWEI

So this is the god the Zhao family
has worshipped for centuries—a
weasel. No... a whole clan of weasels.

He scans the room and spots Jiahui's spirit tablet. He pulls
out the knife and scratches her name off the wood. Then he
stands before the weasel statue.

HUAWEI (cont'd)

My teacher says you're fake. Ghosts,
gods, monsters—none of them are real.
But this time, I hope you are. If you
grant my wish, I'll give you my life.
Just save Jiahui. She must know what
this marriage truly is by now. This
is the last chance, after I killed
Weiguo.

He begins to cry again.

HUAWEI (cont'd)

Technically, I didn't kill him. He
drank the water himself. It was meant
for Guoxin, that bastard. And Weiguo
was dying anyway—surely that was
already written in your death
records, right? On Yama's scroll?
Anyway, I don't care about that. I
love Jiahui.

His gaze hardens.

HUAWEI (cont'd)

I'd do anything for her. But I can't
do it alone. We might both die. So I
beg you. I give you everything.
Protect Jiahui.

The door creaks open. Huawei spins, gripping the knife. An
old man stands there. His eyes are yellow.

OLD MAN

Do I look like a human?

Huawei freezes. His eyes are red.

HUAWEI

Yes.

CUT TO:

INT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — DAY — 2025

HUAWEI

I don't know how much you know about weasels.

Huawei opens the door, inviting Cindy in. The house is large. From the ceiling hang several corpses—but the room is too dimly lit for them to be clearly seen.

CINDY

Mostly that they steal chickens from peasant homes.

Huawei laughs loudly.

HUAWEI

Exactly. Everyone knows the old saying—"A weasel giving New Year's greetings to a chicken—definitely up to no good."

CINDY

Right.

Huawei sits at the dining table, the only space free of hanging bodies. Cindy follows and sits across from him.

HUAWEI

What I mean is—how much do you know about the legends surrounding weasels?

He takes a sip from a bottle of cold cola, then retrieves another from the fridge behind him and places it in front of Cindy.

CINDY

Sorry, I prefer diet coke.

Huawei raises an eyebrow, placing the cola beside himself instead.

HUAWEI

Keeping healthy.

CINDY

Always.

A beat of silence.

CINDY (cont'd)
 As for the folk tales—I've heard
 about the ones asking to be deified,
 and the white fur. The first sounds
 implausible. The second might just be
 albinism. I can't say whether any of
 it's true.

HUAWEI
 That's fair. We've got computers,
 phones, the internet. If a story's
 false, someone will quickly disprove
 it.

CINDY
 And no one's ever truly seen one.
 From a materialist view, it's just
 not credible.

HUAWEI
 According to the tales—if you've seen
 it, then it's real. And I'd say—I've
 seen it.

Silence. Then Huawei bursts out laughing.

CINDY
 Another joke, right?

Huawei nods while laughing.

HUAWEI
 That's your question to think about.
 Not mine.

He stops laughing, his tone flattening.

HUAWEI (cont'd)
 You can find answers at Jing Way No.4
 House.

CINDY
 Jing Way No.4 House?

Huawei doesn't respond. Instead, he turns and walks into a
 bedroom, returning moments later with a paper figurine.

HUAWEI
 You're a materialist. Then take a
 look at this.

CINDY
 What is it?

HUAWEI

As you can see—a paper figure.

CINDY

A witch?

HUAWEI

Not quite. More useful than that. It can block a spirit attack. Once. Also—this.

He hands her an old sheet of paper filled with handwritten Chinese. Cindy takes it and begins reading.

HUAWEI (cont'd)

If you encounter a ghost, recite this. Though—if the ghost is too strong, it may not help.

CINDY

I am searching for these horror stories, or folk legends, yes. But I'm still a materialist.

She frowns.

HUAWEI

Then as a materialist, you should take it.

Cindy hesitates. She slowly accepts both the figurine and the paper, then turns and walks out of the house.

Above her, the corpses hanging from the ceiling seem to twitch. Their tongues loll out, uncontrolled by their mouths—but their eyes lock, unblinking, onto Cindy as she passes beneath them.

EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — NIGHT — 2025

Sam, Cindy, Hajun and Emily sit around a table, each holding a notebook.

SAM

Right, I'll go first with what I found.

Sam pulls out a photo—an image of a wooden hut, dark inside, no door.

SAM (cont'd)

With just a filter, this place looks proper eerie.

EMILY
Honestly, even without it, that place
already looks terrifying.

CINDY
Where did you take it?

SAM
I've forgotten, somewhere near a
stream.

Cindy nods.

CINDY (V.O.)
I didn't notice it. Maybe all my
attention was on Huawei.

EMILY
I didn't find anything weird. But
using the translator, I did talk to a
few old men and learned some of the
local history.

Emily holds up her translation device.

EMILY (cont'd)
They said this area used to belong to
a landlord—all Zhao family. Moved
here around 1915. They were part of
the KMT presence in Beiping—now
Beijing. Most people here were poor.
The Zhao family, though, were loaded.
Back then, the country was fairly
stable, and lots of people wanted to
go to university. But only a few had
the brains. Those who made it were
usually around thirty.

Hajun scratches furiously at his nails, eyes down.

CINDY
Hajun, quiet.

Hajun looks up at her and stops scratching.

EMILY
Some folks came from the
northeast—including the Zhaos. That
meant they basically ruled this
place—more than the KMT, even beyond
what the Republic's laws could touch.
Life here was hard. People were cut
off from the outside world.

CINDY
Which is exactly where folk tales
thrive.

EMILY
Yeah. Anything they couldn't
understand became supernatural.

CINDY
Exactly. And today—I got something
interesting.

Cindy places Huawei's paper on the table. Sam picks it up
first.

SAM
All in Chinese. Can't read a word.

EMILY
Me neither.

Sam takes a picture and runs it through a translation app.

Cindy takes the paper back, reading it carefully.

SAM
Nah, doesn't work. The sentences make
no sense.

Emily looks at his phone and shakes her head.

CINDY
Hajun?

Hajun stares at the table, then slowly lifts his head.

HAJUN
Huh?

CINDY
You interested? I thought Koreans
studied classical Chinese.

Hajun shrugs and takes the paper. He reads in silence. His
legs tremble. Cindy notices but says nothing. He places the
paper down and shakes his head.

CINDY (V.O.)
I've always thought of myself as a
materialist. But tonight—I'm not so
sure. Huawei said he saw a weasel ask
if it looked human.
(MORE)

CINDY (V.O.) (cont'd)
He mentioned this house. The way he appeared... it's too strange. And Hajun—he's gone completely quiet. He seems... unwell.

SAM
Looks like we didn't find anything solid today.

EMILY
Seems that way.

CINDY
Let's try again tomorrow. Maybe we just didn't talk to the right people today.

SAM
Agreed. I'll use the translator too. If we still get nothing tomorrow, I might start thinking there's nothing really here.

They all glance at one another. Sam stands and heads upstairs, disappointed. Emily follows him. They go to their separate rooms.

Cindy walks up as well. Hajun stays seated, staring after her.

HAJUN (V.O.)
I have to get that paper. I must get it. They're all chickens. I'll eat them. I'll eat every last one.

Under the table, Hajun's hand claws at the wood. His nails are sharp and have already gouged into the leg of the table.

INT. CINDY'S ROOM — MIDNIGHT — 2025

Cindy sleeps. A sound from downstairs wakes her. Scratching—nails on wood.

She opens her eyes, grabs her phone, turns on the torch and creeps to the door. She presses her ear against it.

She hears heavy sniffing—like a large animal. Then the scratching again, like a cat sharpening claws. It sets her teeth on edge. She turns and looks at Huawei's paper figure by her bedside.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — FIRST FLOOR — MIDNIGHT — 2025

Cindy opens her door slowly. She steps into the hallway. The moonlight is green—unnatural. The clawing continues. She leans over the bannister, peering down into the living room.

The sound stops. A shadow darts towards the kitchen.

Cindy's breath catches. She pulls out her phone and dials 110—the emergency number in China.

CINDY (V.O.)
Even as a materialist... what if it's
just a beast?

The line doesn't connect. The sound of her phone rings out loud in the eerie silence. From the second-floor railing, Cindy can see the living room directly below—about three metres down.

CINDY (V.O.) (cont'd)
At least... it won't climb stairs.

Suddenly, her vision goes dark. Something crawls up the bannister—fast. Its mouth opens wide and lunges at her. But Huawei's paper figure bursts from her pocket, blocking it. The creature crashes down, smashing into the floor below.

It glares up at her, then bolts out the front door.

CINDY
Hajun!

Sam and Emily burst from Sam's room, half-dressed.

Cindy's eyes go wide. Sam and Emily are equally stunned as they see her—and the smashed hole in the living room floor.

SAM
What the hell just happened?

The floor begins to collapse inward—slow, quiet. The house doesn't shake, but something breaks open beneath it. The three of them stare at the dark hole in shock.

They rush downstairs, phones in hand, torches switched on. The beam of light reveals an enormous coffin deep beneath the house.

The torch beams move slowly across the coffin. The wooden lid is shattered at the head. Inside—Jiahui's face is exposed.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST — MORNING — 1931

Jiahui and Huawei stand at the riverside, both cupping their hands like megaphones, excited.

JIAHUI

I love you! Huawei Zheng!

HUAWEI

I love you too! Jiahui Li!

JIAHUI

I love you very, very much!

HUAWEI

I love you very, very much too!

Their voices echo through the forest.

JIAHUI

I love you a bit more!

HUAWEI

I love you a bit more!

They drop their hands, looking at each other.

JIAHUI

Will you regret coming to this remote place with me?

Jiahui smiles brightly.

HUAWEI

I don't care. As long as I'm with you, I'm happy anywhere.

Jiahui's face glows with joy.

HUAWEI (cont'd)

My parents died under a landlord's oppression in the countryside, because they were poor. But you're different, Jiahui. I'll do everything I can to get you out of this hell. Your brother, your parents—none of them can stop us.

JIAHUI

And if they force me to marry Weiguo Zhao?

HUAWEI
Then I'll kill Weiguo Zhao. Kill
Guoxin Zhao!

Jiahui instantly covers Huawei's mouth.

JIAHUI
No! You'd go to prison for that!
We're supposed to be together
forever!

Huawei gently pulls her hand from his mouth, smiling.

HUAWEI
We'll be together for life. And I'll
only love you—this life and no other.

They look into each other's eyes and embrace.

FU
Jiahui! Huawei!

Fu rushes over, out of breath. Jiahui pulls away quickly.

JIAHUI
A Fu! What are you doing here?

FU
Sorry for disturbing you.

HUAWEI
It's fine. You're Jiahui's childhood
friend—like family.

Huawei smiles, genuinely glad someone else witnesses their
love.

Fu grins, then grows serious.

FU
The Zhao family's wedding setup is
already done. You two should leave.
Jiahui—I'll explain to your mother.

Jiahui is stunned.

JIAHUI
Why so fast?

FU
I don't know the full story, but I've
noticed something.

Fu leans in close.

FU (cont'd)
The young master's not going to make it.

Jiahui's eyes widen.

JIAHUI
Weiguo Zhao's dying? Then why a wedding? Are they planning to marry me to a corpse?

HUAWEI
They want him to die married. I won't let that happen!

Fu nods grimly.

FU
Exactly why you should get out. Huawei—you can't beat a landlord. He's got too many people.

Huawei looks down at Jiahui.

HUAWEI
If I were selfish, I'd run away with her and we'd live happily. But she'd never stop worrying about her parents. We'd never have peace. For her, and for us, we'll find a way to get her mother to call off this wedding.

Fu looks at them, shocked.

FU
You're being irresponsible! Jiahui, tell him!

JIAHUI
He's right.

Jiahui looks at Huawei with warmth.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
If something happens to my parents, we wouldn't be happy anyway.

Fu falls silent.

FU
I don't know what your plan is—just hurry. Once they're fully prepared, it'll be too late.

HUAWEI
Thank you, A Fu.

Fu sighs and walks away. Jiahui and Huawei smile at each other.

EXT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — DAY — 1931

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
Out!

She chases Huawei out with a broom.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (cont'd)
I worked so hard to get Mr Zhao to agree to marry Weiguo to Jiahui, and you show up? As long as I'm alive, you two will never be together!

She slams the door shut.

JIAHUI (O.S.)
Mum! How could you?

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (O.S.)
How could I? I found you a good match and you come home with some boy? Do you want to kill me or your father with worry?

JIAHUI (O.S.)
But I don't even like Weiguo Zhao! How is this different from selling me off?

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (O.S.)
What did you say?! I raised you just to sell you? You went off to university and now you won't listen to your mother? Just because you visited Beiping you think you're some city girl now? Better than us country folk?

Footsteps stomp across the floor.

INT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — SAME — 1931

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
Where are you going?

JIAHUI
To see Weiguo Zhao!

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
You're going after him? No, you're running after that boy! Your brother's gone hungry and cold just so you could go to university—and now he'll never find a wife! You happy now?

JIAHUI
So you sell me to Weiguo Zhao?

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
Yes! What's wrong with that? He's willing to marry you—it's a blessing!

JIAHUI
President Jiang spoke of the Three Principles—democracy, do you know it? What civilised country forces daughters into marriage? That's last century's thinking! You're still trapped in feudalism!

She turns to leave. Her mother rushes over and grabs her arm.

JIAHUI'S MOTHER
Think you're grown now? Bringing up foreigners? I don't care who comes today—you're not leaving!

EXT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — SAME — 1931

JIAHUI (O.S.)
Let go of me! Let me go! Mum, you've gone mad!

Huawei steps forward, hand raised to open the door—then stops. His eyes drift, unsure.

Footsteps grow louder from inside. Huawei quickly hides nearby.

Jiahui's mother exits, glances around. She doesn't see Huawei, and walks off.

Huawei looks at the house, then after her.

HUAWEI (V.O.)
 Jiahui's father must still be inside.
 Even if I went in—it wouldn't help.

He quietly follows Jiahui's mother.

INT/EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MOMENT LATER — 1931

SERVANT C
 Sorry, sir. This is a private
 residence. You can't come in.

Huawei watches as Jiahui's mother walks inside. He cannot follow.

EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — PERIMETER — DAY — 1931

Huawei stands on tiptoe, trying to peer into the courtyard. He sees and hears nothing.

He walks to a corner of the courtyard and sits, waiting.

A yellow weasel crawls slowly toward him. Huawei notices it and watches curiously. The weasel sees him, then bolts.

Huawei follows, arriving at the stream, near a forest. The weasel disappears into the trees. Huawei moves to follow it.

GUOXIN (O.S.)
 Weiguo's condition is critical. I
 just hope he survives until the
 wedding.

TING (O.S.)
 (sobbing)
 The wedding doesn't matter! Can't you
 beg the weasel immortals to save our
 son?

GUOXIN (O.S.)
 Of course I want to... but—

Huawei ducks into hiding. He sees Guoxin and Ting approach.

TING
 But the harvest was so good this
 year... because you sacrificed Weiguo,
 didn't you?

Guoxin says nothing.

TING (cont'd)
 Answer me! Why are you silent now?

GUOXIN
 We'll have more children. I failed
 Weiguo. He won't even outlive me.

Ting cries harder.

GUOXIN (cont'd)
 No one in our family has ever died
 unmarried. We follow tradition.

TING
 And the weasel immortals? What do
 they say?

Guoxin glances upstream.

GUOXIN
 This time I've asked someone else.
 Let's not disturb them again.

Ting stares at him in disbelief.

TING
 What did you say? This isn't
 ordinary—it's a ghost marriage!

Huawei stares at the two in shock, frozen in place.

Guoxin gestures sharply for silence.

GUOXIN
 Don't speak of such things outdoors!
 They might hear you!

TING
 So you do fear them. You know he's
 going to die. You know
 everything—what won't you do?

GUOXIN
 Everything I do is for this family!

TING
 Including killing me?

GUOXIN
 Never! But listen. If Weiguo doesn't
 marry, we'll have no children left.
 We destroy tradition. The weasel
 immortals can't help us this time. So
 you must obey.

Huawei makes a noise. Guoxin turns abruptly but sees no one.

GUOXIN (cont'd)
Quick—we need to go. That mad woman's
probably already arrived. We must
plan carefully.

He pulls Ting away. Huawei steps out, disoriented, staring where Guoxin had looked.

A white weasel appears by the stream, drinking water. Its movements resemble a human's.

Huawei suddenly realises—it's white. He stares, frozen.

The weasel bows to Huawei.

Huawei falls backwards in fear. After a moment, he scrambles up and runs.

EXT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — MOMENT LATER — 1931

Huawei bangs on the door.

HUAWEI
Jiahui! Jiahui!

She opens it.

JIAHUI
I drugged my father and brother.
You're just in time!

HUAWEI
Jiahui—we're leaving! Now!

He grabs her hand and pulls her along.

JIAHUI
What's going on?

They reach the dirt road. Huawei looks around. No cart. He pulls her toward the edge of the village.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
Huawei? Huawei? Say something!

Huawei doesn't answer. Keeps walking.

Jiahui yanks her hand free.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
If you don't speak, I'm not going
anywhere.

HUAWEI
Don't ask yet. Once we're out, I'll
explain.

He tries to take her hand again. She pulls away.

JIAHUI
Say it now.

She looks at him sternly.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
What do you know?

Huawei stays quiet, then speaks softly.

HUAWEI
They said... you must marry Weiguo
Zhao. Even if you don't want to. Even
if he dies today, they'll force a
ghost marriage. They'll kill you.

Jiahui stares, disbelieving.

JIAHUI
My mother—does she know?

HUAWEI
I don't know.

They stand in silence.

JIAHUI
What if... we kill Weiguo Zhao?

HUAWEI
No. They'd come after you. Even more
violently.

Jiahui starts crying. She looks to the sky.

JIAHUI
(choked)
So that's it?

HUAWEI
Unless—

JIAHUI
Unless we kill Guoxin Zhao.

HUAWEI
Then we're no better than them.

JIAHUI
It's for our future.

Huawei freezes, staring at her.

HUAWEI
Will you marry me?

Jiahui, still crying, grabs his hand and runs.

EXT. FOREST INTERIOR — AFTERNOON — 1931

Jiahui leads Huawei to a stone in the forest.

HUAWEI
What is this?

JIAHUI
It's the Marriage Stone.

HUAWEI
Marriage Stone?

JIAHUI
Yes. They say if two people bury
their bound hair here, they'll be
together forever.

Huawei looks at the stone.

HUAWEI
Alright.

They each pluck strands of hair, tie them using a torn piece
of Jiahui's clothes, and bury them under the stone.

HUAWEI (cont'd)
Is this what they call "hair-bound
spouses"?

Jiahui nods.

HUAWEI (cont'd)
Can I believe that from now on—I'm
your husband?

JIAHUI
You'll always be my husband. Until
death.

HUAWEI
And you'll always be my wife. Death
won't part us.

Jiahui smiles softly.

JIAHUI
Where did you learn such a line?

HUAWEI
Western weddings. The priest says it.
You're supposed to say "I do."

Jiahui blinks at him, eyes full of love.

Huawei stares into hers.

They lean in and kiss.

Afterwards—

JIAHUI
I do.

HUAWEI
I do.

EXT. FOREST INTERIOR — NIGHT — 1931

They find a cave, lying together inside.

HUAWEI
If we really do kill Guoxin Zhao—how
do we escape?

Jiahui rests in his arms.

JIAHUI
We stay here. Block the entrance with
hay. No one will notice.

HUAWEI
Don't forget the footprints. This
whole area's soft soil. Tracks are
easy to follow.

JIAHUI
I know. I'm clever, remember?

Huawei kisses her gently.

HUAWEI (V.O.)
But I won't let you take that risk.

He watches her slowly drift to sleep.

HUAWEI (V.O.) (cont'd)
I'll do it alone. If it's not
killing—if it's just poison—I can
manage. Jiahui, I love you.

CUT TO:

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MORNING — 1931

HUAWEI (V.O.)
After parting with Jiahui, she
returned home, and I made an excuse
to buy poison. In truth, I study
clinical medicine. I prepared the
poison last night in the wild—it's
not just sleeping powder. I'm certain
the Zhao family would never send
Guoxin Zhao's body to Beiping for an
autopsy. In their eyes, to let a
forensic examiner—what we call a
wuzuo—cut open the dead is the
greatest disrespect.

Huawei, dressed as a Zhao family servant, waits outside Jing Way No.4 House. Unlike the others, he positions himself closer to the entrance, so if summoned, he'll be first to hear and have a legitimate reason to enter.

A coughing fit breaks out inside. The servants all flinch.

Huawei looks at a nearby servant, clearly afraid.

HUAWEI
Hey, you.

Servant F points to himself. Huawei nods.

HUAWEI (cont'd)
Brother, I'm new here. Why's the
master coughing so badly?

SERVANT F
You don't know?

Huawei shakes his head.

SERVANT F (cont'd)
You know the Zhao family worships
weasels as gods, right?

HUAWEI

That much I know.

SERVANT F

Let me tell you straight—worshipping
weasel spirits costs your lifespan.

Huawei widens his eyes.

HUAWEI

It shortens your life? That serious?

SERVANT F

It depends on what the master offers.
Things have been calm for years—until
this year's drought. So he's offered
some of his own years to the weasel
immortals.

HUAWEI

I see.

SERVANT F

As servants, we need to know this. We
don't get sacrificed, but when the
oldest in the family dies, we're
buried with them.

Servant F eyes Huawei.

SERVANT F (cont'd)

You and I are in trouble, mate. We've
barely started here and might not
last long.

HUAWEI

Yeah... my family sold me here 'cause
we're poor. Turns out they just sent
me to my own execution.

SERVANT F

That's a grim way to put it. But not
wrong. You've been to school, yeah?

HUAWEI

A few years. Didn't mean much. Here,
it's money that talks.

SERVANT F

Exactly. That's power. Look at
President Chiang—rich as anything.
He's the boss. But what's that to us?

HUAWEI

True. But he does promote the Three Principles. Equality, for the people.

SERVANT F

Three what? I've no clue. I just want to live somewhere I'm not waiting to die. That's a good country to me.

HUAWEI

It takes time for people to have good lives. No country gets it right straight away. Trust the Nationalists. For the nation, for the people.

SERVANT F

Sod that. I reckon the Communists sound better. If they came looking for me, I'd join. I've got nothing worth sacrificing for the Zhao lot. Why should I be buried for them? If I die, they won't die with me, will they?

HUAWEI

What's your death got to do with him?

SERVANT F

Exactly. And what's his death got to do with me?

Huawei sees no use in arguing. He looks toward the house.

ATTENDANT A

Two of you! Come in!

Huawei and Servant F exchange glances. Neither realises how close to the door they've wandered. Now they must enter.

ATTENDANT A (cont'd)

Prepare the decoctions! Master and young master need their medicine.

HUAWEI & SERVANT F

Yes, sir.

They head to the kitchen to start brewing the medicine.

SERVANT F

How did we end up at the bloody door?

He tilts his head, thinking. He tosses a packet of herbs into a pot. Huawei hands him a bowl of water spiked with purgative.

HUAWEI

This... I haven't learnt how to do it.

Servant F accepts the water, drinks, and adds another packet into the pot with fresh water.

SERVANT F

I'll show you. It's easy. Three top-ups when it boils—that's it. I'm off to the loo. Can't hold it anymore.

HUAWEI

No problem.

Servant F rushes out. Huawei is alone.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MOMENT LATER — 1931

Huawei carries a bowl of medicine. Fu storms over.

FU

You're slow. Take it to the young master—now.

Huawei keeps his head down when he sees Fu. He turns and enters through the side door, places the bowl next to the bed, and slips out silently.

HUAWEI (V.O.)

No one will disturb us now, Jiahui.

As Huawei exits, the village doctor enters. Servant F returns.

SERVANT F

All good?

HUAWEI

All good. Why so quick?

SERVANT F

Said it was diarrhoea. Truth is, I'm always half-starved, so it never lasts long.

Huawei says nothing, looking up at the sky.

DOCTOR

The young master is dead!

Huawei's eyes widen. Servant F dashes inside. Huawei bolts the other way.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — NIGHT — 2025

SAM
What the hell was that? Someone explain!

The three of them sit at the dining table, barely holding back fear.

CINDY
We need to call the police!

EMILY
No!

Emily cuts her off instantly.

EMILY (cont'd)
What about Hajun?

CINDY
Hajun is dead! He's been replaced by the weasel!

SAM
What?! Why?!

Cindy sighs.

CINDY
Hajun went out that day. When he came back, I saw him. He was off-kept talking about weasels and gods. And tonight, he attacked me. I think... it was because of that piece of paper.

SAM
Why do you think that?

EMILY
Don't jump to conclusions. It was just an accident.

CINDY
What sort of accident lets Hajun climb to the second floor, attack me, and fall hard enough to smash a bloody hole in the floor where we saw a coffin?

EMILY
Anyone falling would make a dent. We
have to stick with science first.

CINDY
He ran off right after crashing down.
Didn't seem hurt at all.

Emily shrugs.

EMILY
Maybe... like Monster.

CINDY
Exactly!

EMILY
The drink. Monster drink. Got him too
wired.

Cindy turns to Sam silently.

SAM
What? This is exactly the kind of
woman they write in American horror
films.

EMILY
Hey, Sam. We were just having sex and
you called me clever.

SAM
Men say all sorts in bed. Doesn't
count.

CINDY
We're probably all in danger now.
That coffin—

SAM
Brilliant. From both legal and
folklore perspectives, you're
right—we're screwed. So Emily, kindly
stay quiet.

EMILY
Fine. I'm going back to bed. I'm sure
by morning, you'll both have sorted
it.

SAM
Great idea.

Cindy says nothing. Emily heads upstairs.

SAM (cont'd)

Right, now we can actually talk about this madness.

CINDY

I just want you to believe it. Whatever's happening—there's no scientific explanation so far.

SAM

True. Or maybe it's just something we don't understand yet.

CINDY

Look, Hajun's not himself. Until we figure this out, we avoid him. Also, I'm sure this paper is part of it. Someone gave me two things—that paper, and a paper figure.

SAM

Paper figure? You never mentioned that.

Cindy reaches into her pocket and pulls out half a torn paper figure.

CINDY

It's ruined now. But maybe that's what saved me.

SAM

Like a crucifix, but single-use.

CINDY

Pretty much.

SAM

Got it.

EMILY (O.S.)

Aaargh!

CINDY

Emily!

They look at each other, bolt upstairs. Sam slams the door open with all his strength.

INT. EMILY'S BEDROOM — NIGHT — 2025

Cindy and Sam see Emily curled up by the bed. She points, terrified, toward the window.

Sam follows her finger—nothing there.

He rushes to her side.

SAM
What did you see?

Cindy glances at Sam, then at the ghost hanging outside the window.

EMILY
There was a corpse outside my window.

SAM
What corpse?

He looks again, confused.

SAM (cont'd)
Don't worry. You're alright.

He hugs Emily, gently patting her back, looking to Cindy.

Cindy nods. Sam frowns.

CUT TO:

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — GROUND FLOOR — NIGHT — 2025

Sam holds Emily on the sofa. Cindy stares at the hole beside them.

Cindy takes out Huawei's paper. Strange passages are written on it.

SAM
So, what does it say?

CINDY
Something about the underworld. The man told me—if you see anything strange, read these lines.

SAM
Do you believe him?

CINDY
My education says no. My survival instinct says yes.

Cindy carefully reads the Chinese text.

CINDY (cont'd)

(in Chinese)

From eightfold ways they tread to
gloom, to Yama's hall the judges
loom. Yet fate not follows nether
course, 'fore souls go beasts of
ghastly force. The sin-bound scribe
doth watch mankind, on stage of
tears, what truths to find. No mortal
sees the shadowed ford, where Heaven
weaves all cause and chord.

A creaking sound echoes from the hole-old wood straining. It
stops quickly.

SAM

Did it work?

CINDY

I don't know. You heard that, right?

SAM

Yeah, but it could've been a
coincidence.

CINDY

Maybe.

SAM

What even is that thing? Did the man
say?

CINDY

No.

SAM

I'm still wondering what those copper
coins were for. Creepy.

CINDY

If they had dog's blood on them, I'd
guess they're for warding off
spirits.

SAM

If they protect, what did your chant
do then?

CINDY

I don't know! My Chinese isn't that
good! It's ancient Chinese, alright?

SAM

Jesus.

The wood creaks again, louder.

CINDY
I don't think that's a coincidence
anymore.

SAM
Yeah, mate. Me neither.

Neither of them moves. Emily, still in Sam's arms, squeezes her eyes shut.

CINDY
I'm too scared to look in the hole
now.

SAM
Same here.

Suddenly, Emily's eyes snap open. She thrashes violently. Sam tries to hold her, but she throws him off with unnatural strength.

SAM (cont'd)
What the hell!

CINDY
Emily!

Emily claws at her own throat, as if something invisible is choking her. Cindy freezes.

Sam struggles to his feet but collapses again.

SAM
Cindy—my leg. I think it's broken.

Cindy snaps back, runs to help Sam onto a low cupboard by the window.

SAM (cont'd)
Emily, no!

Emily tumbles off the sofa. Something pulls her toward the pit. Sam leaps forward with his good leg and grabs her ankle.

Cindy stands frozen. In the corner of her eye, she sees the mirror.

In the mirror—the ceiling is covered with hanging corpses. A rope tightens around Emily's neck, pulling her.

CINDY
Sam! The mirror!

Sam turns to see it. The hanging dead all stare at him, tongues lolling.

Cindy spots the old landline phone, grabs it and hurls it at the mirror. It shatters. The rope vanishes. Emily gasps and collapses.

Sam pulls her to safety and shields her with his body.

Cindy stares, shaking—still trapped in the horror of what she just saw.

SAM
Is it over?

CINDY
I don't know.

Cindy swallows, slowly approaches the pit in the living room, takes out her phone. No signal. She switches on the torch—her phone shuts off instantly.

SAM
Use mine.

Sam releases Emily, struggles to pull his phone from his pocket. Emily has already fainted. Cindy takes Sam's phone—it's also dead.

CINDY
Useless.

SAM
That's impossible. I left mine charging.

Suddenly, Emily is yanked into the pit. Neither reacts in time.

SAM (cont'd)
No!

Cindy is frozen. Slowly, she turns to look into the pit. Moonlight falls through the main door, casting light across Jiahui's face. The copper coins over her eyes have fallen off.

Sam crawls to the edge, peering down. Emily lies impaled on a jagged plank of the coffin, right on top of Weiguo.

The moon is quickly covered by clouds. The room darkens again—eerily silent.

CINDY
Sam, I've got a suggestion—run.

Wooden creaking echoes louder from the pit. Cindy glances up. In the shards of the broken mirror, the house appears transformed—draped in white mourning silk. Above the coffin hangs a red character: Xi.

Sam doesn't move, frozen, staring into the pit.

CINDY (cont'd)
Sam? Can you hear me? I've got a bad feeling. We need to go. Now.

Sam still doesn't react. Suddenly, a pair of bluish hands grab him and yank him into the pit.

CINDY (cont'd)
Aaargh!*

EXT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MIDNIGHT — 2025

Cindy bolts out of the villa in a panic, running away from the creek. Music grows louder—sorna pipes, gongs, drums. A traditional Chinese wedding tune.

She turns and sprints towards the creek instead. Barely fifty metres on, she sees figures carrying a red bridal sedan emerging.

In the opposite direction, hell money flutters through the air.

CINDY (V.O.)
A wedding, red. A funeral, white. How can they both happen at the same time? Run. Just run!

Music and wooden creaks from the sedan grow louder from both ends of the road. Cindy finally sees the players—none of them are human. The musicians and sedan-bearers are all paper effigies used in funerals.

Cindy gasps for air.

CUT TO:

EXT. FIELDS — DAY — 1919 — FLASHBACK

Everything is hazy.

JIAHUI (O.S.)
A Fu? A Fu?

Cindy sees nothing clearly.

JIAHUI (O.S.) (cont'd)
A Fu?

JIAHUI
A Fu?

Finally, Cindy sees a young girl—child Jiahui. Cindy can't move; she lies on the ground.

FU
Jiahui? What are you doing here?

Fu pushes himself up—his hands are small and childlike.

JIAHUI
Mum's pregnant. Can't keep an eye on me. I packed some eggs and came out!

FU
You're amazing! So quick!

JIAHUI
Of course.

Jiahui wears a pale yellow dress, faded. She sits beside Fu.

Fu blushes, avoids eye contact.

JIAHUI (cont'd)
It's lovely here. Quiet. No mum nagging. No parents arguing.

Fu lies back in the grass.

FU
Only freedom here.

JIAHUI
I heard Beiping is lively. I really want to see it.

FU
Sounds exciting!

JIAHUI

Last time I went with Dad to buy seeds—we saw candied hawthorn. So pretty. So expensive.

FU

Don't worry!

Fu jumps up.

FU (cont'd)

When I grow up, I'll take you to live in Beiping! I'll earn loads of money and buy you all the candied hawthorn you want!

JIAHUI

Really?

FU

Really!

JIAHUI

Wow, A Fu, you're amazing!

EXT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — NIGHT — 1920 — FLASHBACK

JIAHUI'S MOTHER (O.S.)

You useless man! Home this late again. Can't farm. Can't raise a daughter. How's our son supposed to grow up and find a wife in this poverty?

Fu holds a crying Jiahui outside her house.

JIAHUI

We went to Beiping today... I shouldn't have asked Dad for sweets... I'll never eat hawthorn again.

Fu holds her tighter, deep in thought.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — DAY — 1920 — FLASHBACK

FU

Mr Zhao, please let me serve your family.

GUOXIN

Oh? You're just a boy. What can you do? Why should I feed you?

FU

If you tell me to walk east, sir,
I'll never once look back west.

TING

He's got spirit. Your name's A Fu, is
it?

FU

Yes, Madam.

TING

Are you starving? Got no clothes?

FU

No, Madam.

TING

Then why sell yourself to us?

FU

I need money! I want a better life.
Tired of being bullied.

Guoxin laughs loudly.

EXT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — DAY — 1925 — FLASHBACK

JIAHUI

A Fu, I don't want to marry Weiguo
Zhao. Can you speak to the master for
me?

FU

I'll do my best. I've got six years.
I'll climb high enough to persuade
him.

JIAHUI

I believe in you.

A loud slap rings out.

INT. BARN — NIGHT — 1927 — FLASHBACK

JIAHUI

This is your solution, A Fu?

FU

Young master Weiguo likes virgins. If you fail tomorrow's test, I can get you out of this! Trust me! It's the only way!

Jiahui stands, trembling.

JIAHUI

I thought you were my brother. I never imagined... I'll fix this myself. I don't need your help!

INT. BARN — DAY — 1927 — FLASHBACK

WEIGUO

You let Jiahui go? Who gave you the balls? I'll curse your whole bloody family! You bastard! Son of a whore! I waited three bloody years for her—and you let her go?! Fine! You parentless cur—I'll castrate you today!

He whips Fu mercilessly. Blood pools beneath him.

EXT. VILLAGE ENTRANCE — DAY — 1931 — FLASHBACK

FU (V.O.)

Jiahui's back? She's really back! I've just poisoned Weiguo! I must tell her!

Fu runs to the gate. Two figures wait—turn slowly.

Jiahui waves happily.

JIAHUI

A Fu, long time no see.

Her smile is radiant. Fu clutches his chest.

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — NIGHT — 1931 — FLASHBACK

GUOXIN

Weiguo's weaker by the day. Should we still go ahead with this wedding?

FU

Master, no Zhao has ever died without marrying.

(MORE)

FU (cont'd)

A master I know says our worship of weasels means—we break the tradition, we lose our bloodline.

GUOXIN

What? But the nearest good wedding date's half a year off. He won't survive that long!

FU

Yes, but the next good funeral date is very soon.

GUOXIN

What do you mean?! A Fu, are you saying you want my son to die faster?!

FU

Of course not, Master. I mean—spirit marriage. Her name's Siu Yin.

INT. JIAHUI'S HOUSE — NIGHT — 1932 — FLASHBACK

FU

Jiahui, look. They're all here—the ones who hurt you.

Fu stands on a stool before a mirror. In the reflection: all the people who wronged Jiahui hang by their necks—Guoxin, Jiahui's mother, brother, Ting. Jiahui's photo is stuck at the top of the mirror.

FU

(choked)

I've avenged you, Jiahui. I see you in my dreams every night. I can't take it anymore. I was wrong. I'm sorry.

Tears stream down Fu's face.

FU

There's only one person left in this world who hurt you—me.

He looks at Guoxin.

FU (cont'd)

Master, let's atone together.

Fu slips a rope over his neck. Kicks the stool. Begins to choke. Stares at Jiahui's photo as he dies, reaching for it one last time.

CUT TO:

INT. JING WAY NO.4 HOUSE — MIDNIGHT — 2025

Cindy slowly opens her eyes. She tries to move—she can't. Her arms and legs are bound to a timber frame. She wears a traditional Chinese bridal gown. Fu sits calmly on the sofa, holding the parchment. He hears her stir and turns with a smile.

CINDY

You're not Huawei. You're A Fu.

Fu stands, still smiling.

FU

Clever girl.

CINDY

Didn't you want me to find out?

FU

Of course. I've cultivated my spells for ninety-three years, and yet... I still carry sentiment.

CINDY

You're no longer human. So why keep killing? You already destroyed the Zhao family, and Jiahui's entire family. Why?

FU

I thought you'd figured that out.

Cindy looks at Sam and Emily's headless bodies. Blood seeps from their necks into the coffin below. She remembers Hajun.

FU (cont'd)

You see. I couldn't allow Jiahui to be reborn in an idiot. She's brilliant.

CINDY

You're insatiable. She never loved you.

FU

She did. She only chose the other one because she thought he'd give her freedom. She was wrong. Only I could. I know her best.

CINDY

What do you know about her?

FU

I grew up with her. I saw her cry, I saw her laugh. I saw her worship me—after I stole her a candied hawthorn.

He takes a worn photograph of Jiahui from his pocket and gently strokes it.

CINDY

She loved the city. Not the candy.

FU

She loved me. Only me. Don't believe me? Fine. Let her speak for herself.

Fu begins to chant from the parchment.

FU

(in Chinese)

From eightfold ways they tread to gloom, to Yama's hall the judges loom. Yet fate not follows nether course, 'fore souls go beasts of ghastly force. The sin-bound scribe doth watch mankind, on stage of tears, what truths to find. No mortal sees the shadowed ford, where Heaven weaves all cause and chord.

The coffin in the pit begins to shake violently. He chants a second time. The temperature in the room plummets. Ice forms across the shards of the mirror on the floor.

CINDY

(realising)

Of course... Calling the dead means drawing them into your presence.

Fu pauses, eyes narrowing at her.

FU

Very clever. I'm impressed.

He resumes the chant. Cindy, shivering, notices four figures standing silently outside—elderly, hunched. Three of them have limbs unnaturally thin and twitching like weasels. The fourth stands upright, almost human.

CINDY (V.O.)
Weasel spirits...

Fu completes the third chant. Ice creeps up the walls. A sudden snarl—

Hajun leaps from the shadows and sinks his teeth into Fu's shoulder.

FU
You—You're that Korean boy?

Hajun rips into Fu's arm, then is kicked away. Fu staggers.

FU (cont'd)
You're not him. You're Huawei!

A column of black mist rises from the coffin, winding its way toward Cindy.

Hajun's eyes now glow green. His claws extend. He lunges again.

Cindy trembles. Her vision blurs.

Fu throws Hajun across the room. Hajun hits the ground hard.

HAJUN
(in Huawei's voice)
You tricked us.

FU
Huawei! Jiahui is mine! She always was!

HAJUN
Jiahui. Is. Freedom.

He charges, but Fu summons paper effigies which wrap around him, dragging him to the floor in a struggling heap.

Cindy's vision dims. Outside, the weasel elders vanish.

She loses consciousness.

Fu, bloodied, crawls to Cindy. He slumps beside her.

FU

She's mine now. No one can take her
from me again.

Cindy's skin purples. The veins in her hands turn black. Her
nails lengthen, curling.

CINDY

(softly)

A Fu.

Fu jolts upright, disbelief on his face. He strains to look
at her.

FU

Jiahui?

A sharp crack. A fingernail drives through his skull. His
head falls from his shoulders.

INT. ANCESTRAL SHRINE — DAWN — 1931

Jiahui places a name plaque, carved with her own name,
beside the statue of the weasel deity. She kneels in the
centre of the shrine.

JIAHUI

I don't know if I'll make it out
alive this time. But I'm already
married to Huawei. I have no regrets.
Great Weasel Immortal, if I die
tonight, let me return as a wrathful
ghost. Give me the chance to kill
every one of them. No matter how long
it takes.

She stares at the weasel statue, then bows low, pressing her
forehead to the floor.

She turns to the window. Tears glisten in her eyes. She
wipes them away with her sleeve, walks to the offering
table, lights three sticks of incense from a candle, gently
blows on the flames, then places them into the burner before
the statue.

She steps back to the centre of the shrine, kneels again.
Her head touches the floor. She raises both palms above her
head, facing upward.

JIAHUI (cont'd)

If you can grant me this wish, I
offer you the whole of my life.

The window creaks open in a sudden gust.

The eyes of the weasel statue twitch. Ever so slightly.

FADE OUT.

THE END